CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

PERMANENT MAKEUP ARTIST IN THE AI ERA

Makeup that survives sleep, sweat and swimming — applied once, by hand, a hair-stroke at a time.

★ TL;DR — YES — on the corrected price. There is no BLS occupation and no verified median for this work; the honest figure is ~$55K gross (a ZipRecruiter posting average via PMUHub, 2021), with beginners well below it. The $75K the old card printed traces to a training vendor's unsourced sales-page claim — debunked in the warning below. What survives the correction: $400–$800 tickets, a built-in annual touch-up cycle, a permit measured in weeks, and an industry shakeout that is removing the under-trained instead of the demand. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

OUR TAKE: YES

MEDIAN ~$55K · TRAINING 1-6 months · AI RISK LOW · CERTIFICATE

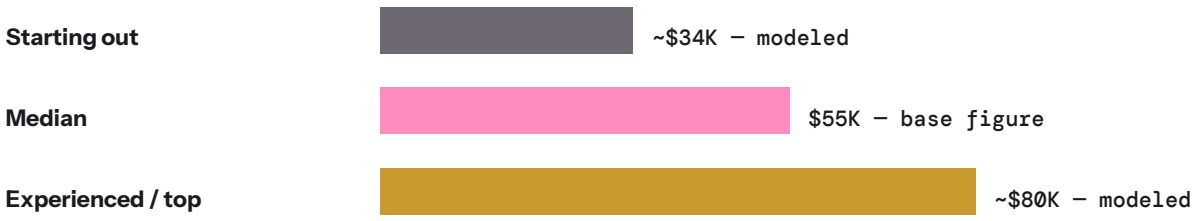
- Why it works: the shortest licensed entry in this batch — a 100-hour+ fundamental plus state body-art registration — against per-procedure tickets of $400–$800 and repeat demand engineered into the service (annual touch-ups at $200–$400).

- Where it bites: tickets are gross, not income — the touch-up session is commonly bundled into the price unpaid, and rent, supplies, insurance and self-employment tax come out before you do. Beginners price at the low end of the $100–$600 range.

- The industry angle: the American Academy of Micropigmentation's own Dec 2025 analysis calls this a 'shakeout phase — a natural correction where oversaturation gives way to higher standards', with the market 'not shrinking, it is refining'. Trained entrants inherit the clients the 2–3-day courses lose.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Permanent Makeup Artist is a ~$55K median (compiled from U.S. labor-market data (this title has no separate BLS occupation; the figure is a market/anchor estimate)). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A PERMANENT MAKEUP ARTIST ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Map and design brows, lips and liner on each client's face
- ✓ Implant pigment with machine or manual tools in sterile procedure
- ✓ Run consultations, patch tests and strict hygiene protocol
- ✓ Photograph fresh and healed results; coach aftercare

Think: tattoo precision meets makeup artistry, on the least forgiving canvas there is.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Design previews and mockups can be generated digitally for client approval; stencil prep and records software speed the paperwork. No AI screens contraindications, implants pigment or carries the liability.	Mapping pigment to skin depth, correcting your own work honestly, and aftercare coaching that clients actually follow. The artist is the quality control — and in a shakeout, quality is the whole business model.

⚠ **The $75K autopsy: it matches, nearly to the dollar, a training vendor's unsourced marketing line — 'national average is $75,855 a year' — printed on a one-week-intensive sales page with no methodology and no source. The best labelled anchor available is $55,093 (ZipRecruiter posting data via PMUHub, 2021 — stale and posting-based, and this card labels it as such). Treat every trainer-published earnings figure as marketing; no verified first-year number exists. Real beginner costs: $2,500–$3,000 per single-technique course, $4,500–$5,500 for a proper 5–10-day fundamental, suite or booth rent, consumables — and in New Jersey, a required $1M liability policy before you practise at all.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT

✓ Precision work with premium per-hour math ✓ Clients who return annually by design (touch-ups) ✓ A small, compliant studio can be genuinely yours	✗ Faces are unforgiving — mistakes are semi-permanent and public ✗ Slow, supervised model work before full-price clients ✗ Regulation varies by state and county — paperwork is part of the job

Good fit? You have a cosmetic eye, a surgeon's patience, and you never rush a face.
Bad fit? You want big creative pieces and quick appointments, not faces held to microscope standards.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — ESTABLISHED STUDIO	DOOR B — YOUR OWN SUITE
Train under and work in an established PMU studio: their clientele, their healed results to learn from, and a chair while you build a name. In a shakeout market a reputable studio's name is borrowed trust — the asset a beginner can't buy directly — and supervised procedures on real faces are where competence actually comes from.	Open a compliant suite once healed results and a waitlist exist: lean, premium-priced and fully yours — licensing, hygiene, unhappy clients included. General salon data puts suites at $1,200–$2,500/mo, owed from month one, so this is the second move, not the first.

Smart move: Document healed results religiously. Fresh work is marketing — healed work is proof, and proof is what premium clients buy.
Where you land after: A premium-priced signature practice, your own studio, or training new PMU artists — the trained side of the shakeout.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
LEARN YOUR	BUY THE	SUPERVISED PROCEDURES,	REGISTER, INSURE,	PRICE LIKE	RIDE THE

STEP 1 — Learn your local rules

RESEARCH FIRST

- PMU is regulated as tattooing/body art — get state and county requirements in writing: registration, facility permit, bloodborne-pathogens course
- The range is wide: Florida's Dept. of Health tattoo artist licence ($60) plus BBP course; California's county Body Art Practitioner Registration; Virginia's dedicated Permanent Cosmetic Tattooer licence (200-hr programme + 60 performances)

STEP 2 — Buy the 100-hour fundamental

TRAINING · WEEKS

- The SPCP/AAM standard fundamental is 100 hours — treat anything shorter as a top-up, not an entry
- Price real programmes: $4,500–$5,500 for 5–10-day fundamentals; $2,500–$3,000 per single technique

STEP 3 — Supervised procedures, healed portfolio

PRACTICE · MONTHS

- Work models under supervision — New Jersey formalises it: 100-hr training plus a 15-procedure apprenticeship with photos
- Photograph healed results; they are the portfolio premium clients judge

STEP 4 — Register, insure, comply

BEFORE CLIENT ONE

- Complete registration/licence and the facility permit; carry liability insurance ($1M where required)
- Set sterile protocol and aftercare systems before the first paying face

STEP 5 — Price like a beginner, honestly

FIRST YEAR

- Enter at the low end of the $100–$600 range and raise on healed proof
- Count the bundled touch-up as unpaid labour inside the ticket — because it is

STEP 6 — Ride the shakeout

ONGOING

- As under-trained competitors exit, standards become your marketing: hours trained, procedures supervised, results healed
- Add services one technique at a time — lip blush $500–$900, eyeliner $400–$700

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

- □ Today: research your state and county rules for permanent makeup in writing.
- □ Days 1–30: a 100-hour+ fundamental started; practice on synthetic skin daily.
- □ Days 31–60: supervised models progressing through brows, lips, liner techniques.
- □ Days 61–90: registration, insurance and compliant studio space arranged; healed portfolio growing.
- □ Day 90: a legal, portfolio-backed practice ready to take full-price clients — priced from evidence, not a sales page.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

· Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test

· Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ FACES ARE FOREVER. TRAIN LIKE IT. ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. labor-market data (this title has no separate BLS occupation; the figure is a market/anchor estimate)). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.